Reading and writing a short story

Nombre: _____ Fecha: _____

Qué vas a aprender

- Recognise the parts of a story: beginning, middle and end
- Identify characters, setting and problem
- Use linking words: once upon a time, one day, suddenly, finally
- Plan and write a short story of your own

Para pensar

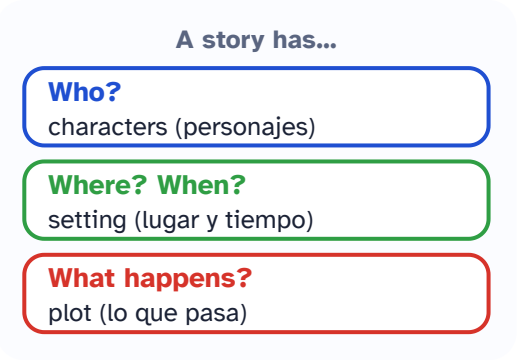
Casi todos los cuentos que conoces empiezan igual: «Érase una vez…». ¿Sabes cómo empiezan los cuentos en inglés?

Explicación

What is a story?

A story tells us about things that happen to some **characters** in a **place**. Stories can be real or invented, funny or scary, about animals, kids, monsters or robots. Fairy tales, fables and comics are all kinds of stories.

Every good story has three ingredients: **who** (the characters), **where and when** (the setting) and **what happens** (the plot). **En castellano:** *story* es «cuento» o «historia»; *tale* también es cuento, y *fairy tale* es un cuento de hadas.



Characters and setting

The characters are the people or animals in the story. The **main character** (protagonista) is the most important one. We describe characters with adjectives: **brave** (valiente), **shy** (tímido), **clever** (listo), **kind** (amable), **naughty** (travieso), **grumpy** (gruñón).

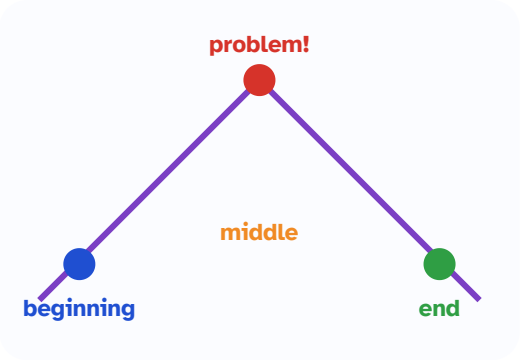
The setting is **where** and **when** the story happens: in a dark forest, in a castle, at school, on a spaceship, a long time ago, last summer... **Consejo:** un buen escenario ayuda al lector a imaginar la historia.

English	Español
brave	valiente
shy	tímido
clever	listo
kind	amable
naughty	travieso

Beginning, middle and end

Stories have three parts. In the beginning we meet the characters and the setting: «Once upon a time, there was a little robot called Bip». In the middle there is a **problem**: «One day, Bip lost his battery». In the end the problem is solved: «Finally, his friend found it and Bip was happy again».

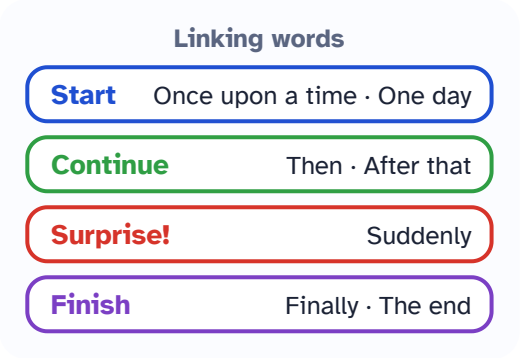
En castellano: es el mismo esquema que en Lengua: planteamiento, nudo y desenlace. Sin problema no hay historia: ¡algo tiene que salir mal para que la aventura sea interesante!



Linking words

Linking words help us tell the events in order. To start: **Once upon a time** (érase una vez), **One day** (un día), **Long ago** (hace mucho tiempo). To continue: **Then** (luego), **Next**, **After that**. For a surprise: Suddenly (de repente).

To finish: **In the end**, **Finally** (al final) and **The end** (fin). **Consejo:** *Suddenly* es la palabra mágica para presentar el problema: «Suddenly, a big storm started...». ¡Engancha al lector!



Stories in the past

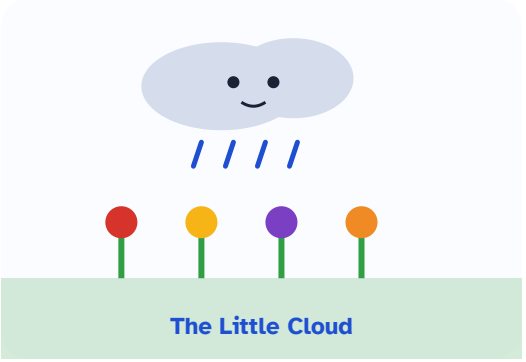
Most stories are told in the **past**. You don't need to know all the past tenses yet, but these verbs appear in almost every story: **was / were** (era, estaba), **there was** (había), **lived** (vivía), **wanted** (quería), **went** (fue), **saw** (vio), **said** (dijo), **found** (encontró), **had** (tenía).

Example: «Once upon a time, **there was** a girl who **lived** near the sea. One day she **went** to the beach and **saw** a bottle». Read them as words and you'll understand the story perfectly.

Past	Español
there was	había
lived	vivía
went	fue
saw	vio
said	dijo

Reading: The Little Cloud

Read this story: «Once upon a time, there was a little cloud called Nimbo. He lived high in the sky with his family. Nimbo was very **shy**. The other clouds made big storms, but he only made a tiny drop of rain. One day, he saw a small village with a dry garden. The flowers were sad and brown. **Suddenly**, Nimbo had an idea. He said: "I can help!". He cried and cried, very softly. **Finally**, the flowers opened and the children danced in the rain. Nimbo wasn't shy any more. The end.»

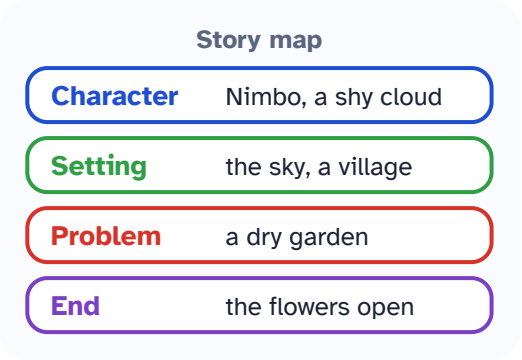


Understanding the story

Let's analyse «The Little Cloud». **Characters:** Nimbo (the main character), his family, the flowers and the children. **Setting:** the sky and a small village.

Beginning: Nimbo is a shy little cloud. **Problem:** the garden is dry and the flowers are sad. **End:** Nimbo makes gentle rain and the flowers open.

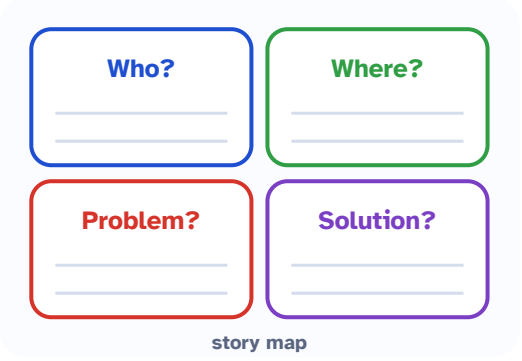
What's the **message** of the story? Maybe: «Small things can help a lot» or «Everyone is good at something». **Pregunta:** ¿qué palabra presenta la idea de Nimbo? (Suddenly).



Planning your own story

Before writing, make a **story map** (esquema). Answer these questions: **Who** is the main character? What is he/she like? **Where** does the story happen? **What** is the problem? **How** is it solved?

Ideas: a dragon who is afraid of fire, a cat who wants to be an astronaut, a pencil that draws by itself, a girl who finds a secret door in the library. **Consejo:** elige una sola idea y un solo problema. Los mejores cuentos cortos son sencillos.



Writing your story

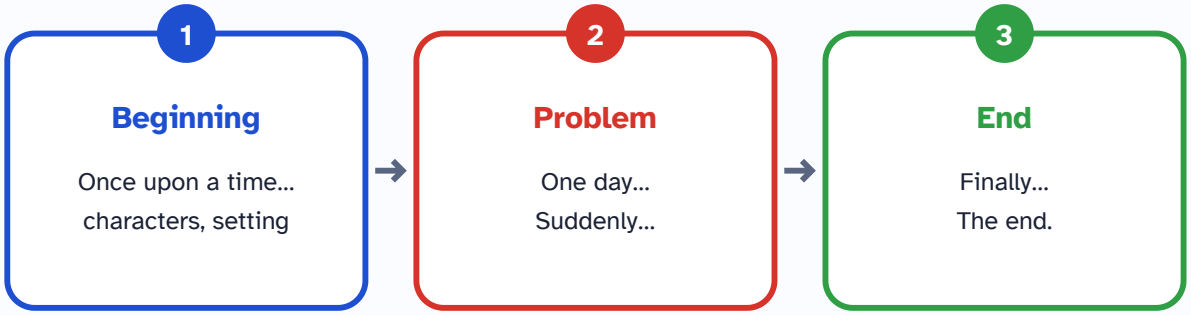
Now write your story in **three paragraphs**, about 60 to 80 words. **Paragraph 1:** «Once upon a time, there was... He/She lived in...». **Paragraph 2:** «One day... Suddenly...». **Paragraph 3:** «Finally... The end».

Check your work with this list: Does it have a title? Are there capital letters at the start of sentences and for names? Did you use full stops (.)? Did you use at least three linking words? Then **illustrate** it and read it aloud to a younger class. **¡Ya eres escritor en inglés!**

Check your story

- ✓ A title
- ✓ Capital letters and full stops
- ✓ Three linking words
- ✓ Beginning, problem, end

The parts of a story



Ejercicios

1. **How do stories start in English?**

2. **Translate: personaje, escenario, problema.**

3. **What are the three parts of a story?**

4. **Which linking word introduces a surprise?**

5. **Translate: valiente, tímido, travieso.**

6. **Who is the main character in «The Little Cloud»?**

7. **What is the problem in «The Little Cloud»?**

8. **Translate: «Había un perro que vivía en un castillo.»**

9. **Write a beginning for a story about a robot.**

10. **Write an ending with «Finally».**

Practica

1. **«Érase una vez» is...**
   - **A)** One time ago
   - **B)** There was one day
   - **C)** Once upon a time
2. **The characters are...**
   - **A)** the people or animals in the story
   - **B)** the place
   - **C)** the title
3. **The setting is...**
   - **A)** the problem
   - **B)** where and when the story happens
   - **C)** the end
4. **Which part has the problem?**
   - **A)** the beginning
   - **B)** the middle
   - **C)** the title
5. **«Suddenly» means...**
   - **A)** al final
   - **B)** érase
   - **C)** de repente
6. **«Brave» means...**
   - **A)** valiente
   - **B)** tímido
   - **C)** gruñón
7. **Which is a word to finish?**
   - **A)** One day
   - **B)** Once upon a time
   - **C)** Finally
8. **«There was» means...**
   - **A)** hay

B) había

C) habrá

9. **In «The Little Cloud», Nimbo is...**

A) shy

B) grumpy

C) naughty

10. **At the start of a sentence we use...**

A) a capital letter

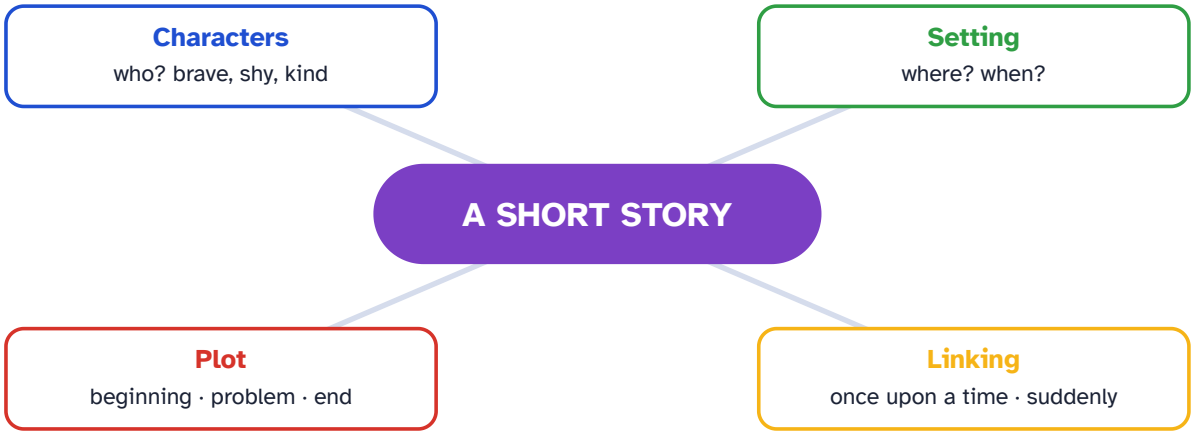
B) a full stop

C) a question mark

Explícalo con tus palabras

Incluye: Qué ingredientes tiene un cuento; Qué son los personajes y el escenario; Las tres partes de un cuento y para qué sirve el problema; Los conectores para empezar, seguir y terminar.

Resumen



Tarjetas de repaso

Recórtalas: pregunta delante, respuesta detrás.

Once upon a time

Érase una vez.

character

Personaje.

setting

Lugar y tiempo del cuento.

beginning / middle / end

Principio / nudo / desenlace.

problem

Lo que sale mal en el nudo.

Suddenly

De repente.

Finally

Al final.

The end

Fin.

Soluciones

1. **C)** Fórmula de inicio.
2. **A)** Personajes.
3. **B)** Escenario.
4. **B)** Nudo.
5. **C)** Sorpresa.
6. **A)** brave.
7. **C)** Final.
8. **B)** Pasado.
9. **A)** Tímido.
10. **A)** Mayúscula.

Soluciones de los ejercicios

1. Once upon a time...
2. character, setting, problem.
3. Beginning, middle and end.
4. Suddenly.
5. brave, shy, naughty.
6. Nimbo, a little cloud.
7. The garden is dry and the flowers are sad.
8. There was a dog who lived in a castle.
9. Model answer: Once upon a time, there was a small robot called Zap. He lived in a big city.
10. Model answer: Finally, Zap found his friends and they had a party. The end.